Duolingo: App updates and lost progress

1. Problem
Bugs and technical issues is the theme with the highest negative rate of any large theme, bringing their negative share to 64% (64% of its reviews are 1 to 2 stars) and the lowest average rating among other large themes, around 2.08 stars. Many of these reviews follow along the line that after an update, it causes progress to get lost or go uncredited.

2. Evidence

109 of 596 negative reviews are regarding bugs and technical issues. (18%)
About 1 in 5 negative bug reviews mention an update. (22 of 109)
Up to about 28% mention lost progress, streaks or rewards.
About 11% mention server, connection or login problems.
In the 30 most upvoted bug complaints I read, 13 were about lost or uncredited progress.

“Updated and completely wiped out my progress”

“recent update says it fixes bugs, instead I get a new bug”

“streak of 94 days is ruined”

3. What I would test
I would test a staged release, where each update goes to a small share of users first. First has to be unit tested by developers. A quality assurance testing team to check through all possible triggers for these bugs. Before it reaches the audience, the team would check that streaks, XP and course progress are still saved. If the check fails, the update is paused.

4. Metric to track
The share of 1 to 2 star reviews that mention an update or lost progress in the week after each release. With Duolingo’s own data, I would also track support tickets about lost progress per 1,000 active users after a release.

5. Limits
One app, 3 weeks of reviews, and a sample weighted toward negative reviews. Themes were tagged by AI and matched my hand check about 62% of the time. The fix is my suggestion and has not been tested.
Next step: extend to 3 months of reviews.